

ENDOCRINE DISORDERS

SOME HORMONES HAVE WIDESPREAD EFFECTS, SO HORMONAL DISORDERS CAN CAUSE PROBLEMS AROUND THE BODY. THE PREFIX "HYPER-" IMPLIES AN EXCESS OF HORMONE, MAKING ITS TARGETS TOO ACTIVE; "HYPO-" IMPLIES TOO LITTLE HORMONE AND UNDERACTIVITY OF ITS TARGETS.

PITUITARY TUMOURS

The central role of the pituitary in the endocrine system is reflected in the problems caused by a pituitary tumour, which may grow in any part of the gland; those in the anterior lobe are more likely to be benign (noncancerous). One result may be excess growth hormone, which causes enlargement of certain bones, such as those in the face, hands, and feet, and of some tissues, such as the tongue, as well as the appearance of coarse body hair and deepening of the voice. This condition is known as acromegaly. Some tumours cause excessive prolactin secretion or overstimulate the adrenal cortex.

PITUITARY TUMOUR

An enlarging tumour may press on the optic nerves that pass just above it, causing headache and visual disturbances, such as losing part of the visual field.

PROLACTINOMAS

About 40 per cent of pituitary tumours are prolactinomas – slow-growing, noncancerous tumours that cause the anterior lobe to secrete excessive prolactin. Normally this hormone promotes breast development and milk production in pregnancy. Symptoms of excess prolactin include irregular periods and lowered fertility in women; breast enlargement and impotence in men; and fluid leakage from the nipples, along with reduced sexual desire. In most cases, medication helps to shrink the tumour and reduce prolactin output; otherwise, surgery or radiotherapy may be necessary.

